

Building a Raft to Cross the Floods of Becoming and Ignorance

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Tonight's talk continues with the teaching known as the raft which describes someone following a path that leads to a shore that is perilous owing to a great expanse of water. Across the water he sees another shore where the ground is secure. He gathers grass, twigs, branches and leaves, binds them together to make a raft and paddling energetically crosses the flood. The near shore, if you remember, stands for self-identity, while the far shore represents freedom. Ultimately, this means the complete freedom of *Nibbāna*, but for the purpose of this sutta, we're best to think of the far shore as those temporary periods of freedom that emerge when we've worked our way mindfully through some struggle. The water refers to the four floods which represent those aspects of life we identify with: sensuality, becoming, views and ignorance. On the near shore we are unwittingly taking on a false identity and will suffer on account of that because sooner or later this identity will be threatened.

Last night we looked at the floods of sensuality and views. Tonight we look at the other floods, starting with the flood of becoming. This flood relates to our identity as a person with a future and a past. It's especially connected with our roles as parent, daughter, technician, cook and so on. More subtly, we also assume social roles such as respectable person, good friend, social activist, etc. We're not fully aware of some of our roles or consciously choosing to play them. For example, we can play victim roles in certain circumstances when we don't know how to cope with misfortune. At other times, we play the role of bully in an attempt to control ourselves or others. In other circumstances, we'll end up playing roles of mother hen, wise owl, grumpy grouse. We have a whole menagerie inside us, waiting for their moment on stage.

Just as sensuality and views can play meaningful, beneficial parts in our lives, our roles can also serve us well. They give us predictable ways of interacting with others which simplifies social situations and lets us all work together well. The problem only comes when we forget that these roles are temporary and contingent. There will come a time when they are not appropriate and unless we can let go we will suffer and so also will our relationships. Retirement for example is a challenge for most people. Our role as electrician or teacher or secretary which we knew so well is suddenly gone. We don't know who we are anymore or what to do with ourselves. As children turn into adults, we find it difficult to let go of parent-child roles.

Why is this flood termed becoming? Why not call it the flood of roles? If we're looking back on our role as teacher or parent, that isn't a problem. It's a way of understanding and appreciating our lives, learning from past mistakes and forgiving these. It's only the projection of that role into the future that gets us

swept off our feet. The energetic pull of the flood is towards the future. So becoming describes the feeling tone of this flood very well.

Retirement and other major role changes in life are strong currents in the flood of becoming. But we get swept away in small ways every day. We can use each of these smaller floods as opportunities to practice making a raft and getting safely to the far shore. In meditation, how often do we get carried away into a fantasy about how wonderful we are? It might be that we're going to write the most spectacular novel worthy of a hundred Man Booker prizes. In another meditation, we'd be climbing Mount Everest without oxygen, winning Wimbledon, awarded the Nobel Peace Prize. These are mini tsunamis in the flood of becoming.

Instead of condemning yourself for these, see how well you can stay afloat in their midst. Body awareness makes a great raft. The mind can be sparking with ideas on how we will impress the world, but the body is sitting there in meditation, grounding us. In my experience, this flood seems to be pulling me towards a very pleasant, enticing future. This imagined future would be reflected in my body as pleasant sensations. If I can locate and hold attention on those sensations, the sparky thoughts and ideas fade and I get a better sense of the energies surging around my body, generating all those pleasant sensations which my mind is interpreting as a wonderful future. At times, then, I might be persuaded to relax a bit, enjoy the pleasure in the here and now.

As I relax, I might detect a couple of separate strands to the energies flowing around my body. At one level, there is self-care, *mettā*. A kindly streak within me is quietly generating pleasant sensations as an expression of care. Then there are the energies driven by desire, clutching onto the pleasure, embroidering a magnificent future out of it. Although I'm strongly attached to this aspect of the experience, I have to admit that the light of awareness shows it up as painful, stressful. Essentially, I'm rejecting the pleasure being offered by my *mettā*-streak, saying, this isn't worth anything, what I need is a great future.

If I can sit with the emotions and feelings generated within this flood of becoming, I'm undermining the delusion at its core. This person I'm so identified with, the soon-to-be Nobel Prize Peace Winner, can I find that person here and now? Are they in my chest, my stomach, my throat, my face? From afar it seems the answer is yes. I might find a hot spot in my throat, for example, where that wonderful person resides. But when I look closely, all I find are physical sensations, pleasant feelings and the deep displeasure of confusion. Where did that wonderful person escape to? Why can't I pin them down?

By now, awareness has penetrated the flood of becoming deep enough to be exploring the underlying flood of ignorance. Caught up in the delusion of self, I'm looking for my essence as something objective that I can know, discern, pinpoint. But I have to admit, sadly, that everything I know keeps dissolving, changing, become other than whatever it seemed to be a moment ago. All very unsatisfactory. Sooner or later, I give up on the futile search. With luck, I'll surrender, for even a few blessed moments, to the truth

of *anattā*. No longer interested in defining myself as an essential separation from the rest of experience. What a relief. A toehold on the far shore.

I'll say a bit more about the flood of delusion later on but for now I want to come back to the flood of becoming and your daydreams about the wonderful person you truly are if only the rest of the world would wake up and take notice. I'm not encouraging you to daydream but to let the raft of *vipassanā* bob up and down on the waves of this flood as you paddle your way to the far shore.

Let's look at a potential tsunami from daily life. Suppose you're a geography teacher standing in front of a class of teenagers. Some of them are listening, some look bored and abstracted, while a group in the back are laughing and chatting. You call for silence, but they ignore you. Jack, stop talking and pay attention, you call to the ringleader. Give me one good reason, sneers Jack, getting a laugh from his buddies. Okay, leave the class now and go to the headmaster's office, you order sternly. Come and make me, he retorts, leaning back in his chair defiantly. Your blood is boiling and you want to murder him. You're also aware that the class has gone still, with all eyes on you to see your next move.

It's the flood of becoming, resting as always on the flood of ignorance, which is making your blood boil. You're identified with your role as teacher and it's under severe threat. If you can't control the situation, the class will lose respect for you and you might also lose confidence in yourself as a teacher. All this is very real. But for spiritual practice, we have to be prepared to look underneath the surface reality. From the spiritual perspective, the danger is that you're being severely tempted to act on anger. Although it can seem counterintuitive, working at the spiritual level can have unexpected benefits at the surface level. If we can muster goodwill in a challenging situation, others often pick up on this and follow suit. For the start, though, we have to put aside any desire for specific outcomes. We have to let all worldly considerations go and give all our heart into gathering bits and pieces for our raft.

Mindfulness would be a great starting ingredient. If you can register your anger and that you're feeling threatened, you will then have some objectivity on the situation. Some degree of calm would greatly help, so you can feel your feet on the ground for a few seconds or take a mindful breath. If you can, add in a *mettā*-wish such as, may I handle this situation wisely? With mindfulness, calm and a degree of *mettā* on board, you may be able to give *mettā* the flavour of equanimity with the wish like, may your behaviour not provoke me to react. This acknowledges the danger of reactivity within a sentiment of goodwill. It forms a wide net for *mettā*. Hopefully your anger will be caught within this.

While none of this changes anything externally, it will have changed things radically within yourself. The situation has now been encompassed within your Dhamma practice, and no matter what happens next, you will be on board a raft rather than drowning in the sea of becoming. You've also saved yourself from the worst outcome – giving Jack a clatter and possibly getting the sack or maybe even being charged with assault. Even if you make an utter fool of yourself and get the sack anyway, it means teaching teenagers was never going to be your career. What matters from the spiritual perspective is not whether you get the

sack but how you handle that setback if it comes.

Supposing mindfulness, calm and mettā got you into some sort of a raft and you feel enough confidence to launch into the flood. My imagination can't stretch to anything more original than, I can't force you out of the class Jack, but I want you to know that I'm appalled by your behaviour and unless it improves radically, I'll be going to the head myself after class with the full story. You're afloat for the moment, but need to be paddling constantly in case any retort from Jack causes a wave to topple you back into fury.

So is there anything else that could add buoyancy? One would be to extend your mettā-wishes to Jack and the rest of the class with something like, May we make it through this crisis? If you have a strong faith you could ask the Buddha or Quan Yin for help or any devas who happen to be nearby. This would be adding faith and devotion to your raft. One very powerful mettā practice is to see all beings as enlightened except for ourselves. Everyone else is playing their roles here on earth with only one purpose in mind, to liberate us from suffering. Our supposed enemies are only pretending to threaten us in order to sharpen our practice. If you could manage even a momentary glimpse of that possibility, it could turn the raft into a cruise ship. No longer are you the teacher, they are the teachers and you are the pupil. This radical shift in perspective may let you see some humour in the situation and find a creative way to handle it.

But suppose you didn't manage to build any raft and are striding towards the back of the class, intending to catch Jack by the scruff of the neck and give him a good clatter. If you've been saying the precepts regularly, then the phrase, not to harm living beings, may pop into your head to bring you to a halt. This would be to start your raft with morality. Acknowledging the harm intended, you might resolve to find some other way of dealing with the situation. To borrow Bhante's phrase, a resolute resolution is what's needed here. I can do no harm. I ought to do no harm. I want to do no harm. I will do no harm. Resolutions are strengthened by a physical gesture and in this case to turn around and walk slowly back to your desk could fit the bill.

The trouble is that you've already let your emotions escalate as well as heightening the tension in the room. So there will probably be a strong temptation towards harsh speech as a means of saving face and regaining some control. Hopefully, you will also remember the precept against wrong speech and start casting around for some wisdom. Equanimity is a major support at times like these. If you practice saying something like, may I not make things worse for myself, during minor difficulties, the phrase may come back to save you in a situation like this. Patience is also a saviour in threatening situations. Patience allows you to acknowledge aversion for the situation and the wish that it would change. But both the aversion and the desire for change are encompassed in equanimity. Phrases like everything in its own time or things are unfolding just as they should strengthen patience. Steadied by morality, resolve, equanimity and patience. You might then be ready to launch into the flood and find some words to resolve the situation.

Let's finish the story on an optimistic note and presume we make a good enough raft and paddle it

energetically enough to get to the far shore. Whatever way the situation played itself out, we've kept our integrity and somehow got ourselves out of danger. It might be hard to think of the incident as a spiritual practice, but keep in mind the image of a rickety raft made out of grass and twigs and leaves. Our practice doesn't have to look pretty. It just has to get us across the floods. Although we'd probably be rattled by the whole experience, we've actually done ourselves a lot of good in spiritual terms, avoiding a severe temptation to indulge anger. Our teacher role has submitted to the demands of the Dhamma, and as a result we would be in a much better position to handle the flood of becoming in future.

Finally, let's look at the flood of ignorance which underlies all the other floods. Ignorance is a harsh sounding word for something as innocent as not knowing how to be happy. Perhaps we could call it the flood of confusion. No matter what we call it, the fact that we don't know how to be happy underlies all our suffering in life. To traverse this flood we need a raft made out of the Four Noble Truths. We need to fully understand *dukkha*, let go of the desires that cause *dukkha* and realize for ourselves there is a state of perfect contentment when we let go of unskillful desire. To accomplish all of these we need to follow the Eightfold Path. We paddle our way through this flood in quiet moments when the other floods have subsided.

We may be sitting quietly at home, physically comfortable, fed and watered, not troubled by anything in particular, just relaxing. But still there's an underlying unease. After a few moments we get restless. We want something to fill our minds, get us going again. This is the flood of ignorance. Even when all the external conditions for peace and contentment are there, we don't know how to be happy. We see this very clearly in meditation practice, how the mind keeps creating stories and dramas to fill up the quietness. Even unhappy stories and bad dramas are preferable to nothing at all.

We also experience the flood of ignorance as we draw near the far shore and have to decide what to do with our raft and it's that aspect of the flood I'd like to focus on tonight. Suppose we had managed to get our cruise ship together and see Jack and all the other pupils as enlightened beings. A great wave of love pulls them into our heart and produces some wise words which resolve the crisis. That wave of love seeps into our geography teaching and the remainder of the class passes like a dream, with everyone, including Jack and his buddies, paying rapt attention.

By the time the class is over, we're walking on air. We've got through the flood of becoming in great style, but we're still in danger from the flood of ignorance. When we're walking on air, it's very easy to believe this is the real me. We think our troubles are over, that Jack will never misbehave again, and even if he does, we know how to handle the situation. Just picture him as the Buddha. What could be simpler?

This, of course, is to be swept away on the flood of ignorance. We've identified with the happiness that has come our way, and think we're in control of it, but we'll always be able to summon it at will. But until we're fully enlightened, our happiness will always depend on conditions. After a while, we'll come down to earth. And at the next class, we might be so shocked to find Jack back to his old tricks that we can't

muster any metaphor for him at all, never mind picture him as the Buddha.

Let's recap on the Buddha's words on getting to the far shore.

And what should the man do with the raft? There is the case where the man, having crossed over, would think, "How useful this raft has been to me! For it was in dependence on this raft that, making an effort with my hands and feet, I have crossed over to safety on the far shore." So we're tempted to hoist the raft on our shoulder and take it with us on our journey. But according to the Buddha, this isn't wise. We're to leave our beloved raft behind. "Why don't I, having dragged it on dry land or sinking it in the water, go wherever I like?" In doing this, he would be doing what should be done with the raft.

So we should first reflect on our raft and appreciate how well it has served us. In this case we would reflect on our ability to picture the pupils as enlightened beings. Doubtless there'll be a temptation to think, "I know how to do this now, I'll always be able to do it." But that would be to carry the raft on our head as we go on our onward journey. It's delusional. We have to rejoice in our raft while letting it go.

Letting go of skillful qualities is one of the major challenges on our spiritual path. It's quite natural to get attached to *metta* and states of deep concentration or joy or tranquillity. Our job, though, is to note these, just as we note physical sensations or any of the hindrances. It is within that objective knowing of these as transient experiences that we can free ourselves from the *dukkha* of false identification.

If we don't manage this, the fall from grace can be very sore indeed. One moment we're light as a feather, loving everyone deeply. Somehow our hold on this gets broken and we're distraught to find ourselves back as the old me, with all of our petty grievances perfectly intact. In fact, we're in a worse mood than usual because of having somehow lost our footing on that wonderful far shore. This can be a very deep shock and sorrow.

One problem is that we often don't know we're attached to something until we lose it. The post-retreat period is a good teacher in this regard. For a while we may be walking on air, at peace with the world and even our old enemies. But somehow we fall back into our old ways. It can be quite shocking to see how easily we get sucked into these sense pleasures, even though we know they're transient and unsatisfactory. Worse still, we can be tempted to blame ourselves and everyone around us for our fall from grace. Even the dog and the goldfish are despicable.

Eventually, of course, things even out and when they do, we will be able to appreciate again the benefits of the retreat, but this time in a more balanced way, knowing that whatever new levels of *metta* or clarity we might experience, they will come and go.

The first time I really became aware of this was after a three-week retreat in Nepal, which had followed on a pilgrimage around India. I was walking on air, inspired and confident that I had undergone an enormous transformation for the better. The exalted state survived the journey back to Delhi, but when the taxi to the airport was over an hour late and no other taxis to be found, it started to quake a bit.

Luckily the plane was even later than my taxi, so I got home all right. But my first night in my own bed was one of deep distress. It really felt like bereavement. I was heartbroken for the loss of that beautiful state of confidence, clarity and inspiration.

Nowadays I try to prepare myself for the fall from grace and to see the post-retreat period as part of the retreat itself. While on retreat I'm often looking forward to the ending and to relaxing the intensity of practice. And at first the wide world seems very lovely but sometime later despondency of one form or another descends. As Sarah, who often does long retreats here at Satipanya, put it, "I can feel worse on retreat, but I know it's all worthwhile. Whereas at home I can feel much better, but there's a background sense that I'm wasting my life." That expresses my own sentiments very well.

I nowadays spend time during the end of the retreat acknowledging the deeper levels of peace, kindness or understanding that I've been noticing from time to time. This is to appreciate the raft. I then remind myself that these aren't mine, that they depend on conditions like the rule of silence, the schedule, the company of other meditators and so on. Although this brings grief, it also allows gratitude to flow for these supports and for Bhante's work in establishing Satipanya and guiding us all along, and for all my efforts to practice during the retreat. During the post-retreat blues, I can then be more compassionate and take care of myself wisely.

Another danger is to neglect practice in the immediate aftermath of a long retreat, to think, "I've done enough of that for the moment, I need a break." To counter this reaction, I arrange to meet up with meditation friends, make a special effort to go to meditation group meetings and to get back into my own daily practice. The more Dhamma supports I can find in the outside world, the easier it is to get through the blues. In summary, the post-retreat period gives us practice at letting go of whatever rafts get us through the floods.

Note that the Buddha gives us two options here. Either we are to sink the raft in water or to drag it onto the beach and leave it there. My understanding is that we sink our raft in the water when we use it to navigate through the flood of ignorance.

Let's take an example. Suppose we have used a raft of *metta* to get us through a flood of views. We're now at ease. We can see the other person's point of view. We see them as a friend and we look back at our little hissy fit. We can giggle at our pettiness. The raft has done its job. So we spend a moment to value our *metta* practice, being grateful for it, resolving to continue to develop this. With that, we simply let the whole matter go. If we were meditating, we would return to the breath. If we were taking a break in daily life, we would move on to the next task. That would be to leave the raft on the beach. A very simple letting go.

Now suppose that as we are reflecting on our *metta* practice, valuing it, being grateful for it, we find it hard to say goodbye, to let it go. We then have to work with our attachment to the beautiful state of *metta*. We acknowledge whatever emotions show up and let them burn out. This is to sink our raft in the water. We are working with the flood of ignorance, seeing more deeply into the second noble truth that desire

for the state of *metta* is causing us to suffer. We're learning the humbling lesson that goodwill is not ours to own. It comes and goes depending on conditions. Ironically, it can make us quite angry to realise that. It's only with lots of patient effort that we can be persuaded to let the raft sink away.

Related to this, we have the Buddha's last words from the sutta: "In the same way, monks, I have taught the Dhamma compared to a raft for the purpose of crossing over, not for the purpose of holding on to. Understanding the Dhamma as taught compared to a raft, you should let go even of Dhammas, to say nothing of non-Dhammas."

Just as we let go of *metta* or whatever got us across the flood, we also have to let go of whatever Dhamma wisdom we have mustered. This again is a deep challenge. We treasure our understanding of the Dhamma. It represents our only hope of happiness. So naturally we get attached. But all attachments bring pain. It's very painful to have to admit that our understanding is insufficient.

In words, it all sounds so simple. Desire causes suffering. Let go of desire and suffering ceases. We agonise within ourselves: "I know that already. Why can't I just do it?" It seems such a mystery. The drill, as we know, is to keep relaxing around the tensions, noting all the protests, the emotions, the confusion, the frustration, until the moment comes when something inside shifts and we're at ease. We might not be able to put into words what we've learned, but we're no longer quarrelling with ourselves. We've experienced again that letting go of desire allows suffering to cease.

But oh, the temptation to attach to our new level of clarity, to think, "OK, now I know and I won't ever get mixed up again." And then unwittingly cause ourselves repeated agony. In this teaching the Buddha emphasises that we must look on our understanding as part of the raft, to be really grateful that it got us across the flood, but then to let it go.

The attempt to do this will show us our attachment. As I reflect on any new level of insight, delight will generally emerge. But in that delight, there's often a streak of pride and my head literally starts swelling. The discomfort of a swollen head shows me very graphically that, despite my new insight, I've still a long way to go. There is then the effort to accept this unpalatable fact and make peace with the unenlightened being that I now am.

To help with the process we can bring to mind the pain of attaching to Dhamma understanding. We experience this in various ways. One is when we try out a different meditation technique. At first it's a welcome change. Then after some time we find it hard to concentrate. It doesn't seem to let us relax as much as our usual method. But our warrior spirit compels us to give it another go. After another aeon of fruitless effort we're confused, angry and frustrated. We can't catch any thoughts. They're exploding all over the place and we believe them all. This turmoil is coming from being attached to views on how to meditate and to our role as competent meditator. So we have the flood of views criss-crossing with the flood of becoming.

When this happened to me, Bhante's advice was excellent: "Stick with the new technique until the aversion passes. Then make a rational decision as to which is better for you." This helped me work through my attachment to the deeply focused form of Mahasi meditation that Bhante encourages.

Another way we can work with this attachment is during Dhamma discussions. We can get hurt when our opinions are challenged or become afraid to express any views. Then again we can be delighted when our opinions prevail, but perhaps there's a tinge of pride in that delight. If we can bear the fear or hurt or pride mindfully, the discussion is actually a very beneficial one. No matter whether we're learning any new information, we're loosening attachment to our Dhamma views.

Reflecting on the pain of attachment makes us more willing to admit that our understanding isn't perfect, that we need to let go. We need to see ourselves as perpetual students rather than give in to temptation and view ourselves as experts. Some statements from arahats reflect a state of continual investigation even after enlightenment. For example, Mechi Kyo says, "I cannot detect a single moment when greed, hatred or delusion have any power over my heart." This indicates that she is still confirming the Dhamma for herself, still investigating.

To see ourselves as perpetual students rather than experts, we are, in the Buddha's words, letting go of the raft of Dhamma. But we can love the raft even while we let it go. We can celebrate and cherish every scrap of understanding that helped us through the flood. Essentially, this is a *mudita* practice, celebrating what is ephemeral, transitory, disappearing in front of our eyes.

Before closing, I'd like to go back to the beginning. The sutta starts out with someone following a path that leads to a perilous shore. So too our spiritual journey is always leading us to new challenges. It's interesting that the Buddha doesn't ever suggest turning back and retreating along the path. This signifies that we can't escape spiritual challenges by keeping to sections of the path we already know.

Supposing you've excellent concentration and can easily access tranquillity when you follow your breath. As the geography teacher under attack from Jack, you could simply let all your attention dwell on your breath. And so your anger would pass and you could go on with the class, ignoring the tensions caused by the incident. If you do the same thing whenever the memory of the incident comes up in meditation, then you won't be developing spiritually. It would be like turning back on the path whenever you come to a perilous shore, and the Buddha isn't recommending that.

Instead, we must take our practice to the edge of our comfort zone, to where we don't know what to do and are flying on a wing and a prayer. That's where we build our raft. And that's how we learn the Dhamma.

May our Dhamma understanding serve us as a raft until, safe at the far shore, we lay down our raggle-taggle of knowledge and skill and move unburdened onwards.

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Transcriptions produced locally using Swiss low-carbon electricity. Corrections and rewriting by cloud-hosted AI.